PRESS INFORMATION BUREAU
GOVERNMENT OF INDIA

NATION'S DETERMINATION TO OVERCOME DIFFICULTIES

DETERRENT ACTION AGAINST ANTI-SOCIAL ELEMENTS

PRIME MINISTER CALLS FOR PEOPLE'S COOPERATION

New Delhi, Sravana 24, 1895
August 15, 1973

Following is the free rendering of the Prime Minister, Shrimati Indira Gandhi's speech delivered in Hindi from the ramparts of the Red Fort this morning:

"Once again we gather at this historic place to celebrate the anniversary of our Independence to pledge ourselves to defend our national flag and to serve our beloved people. Our Independence Day falls during the monsoon when sun and shade intermingle which is symbolic of the intermingling of joy and sorrow in the life of a nation as much as in the life of an individual. Ours is a country of farmers. We welcome the rains because the farmers and the entire country depend on this. Our irrigation and power resources and many other programmes depend on the rains. But today we are under clouds of different kind, the clouds of difficulties and sufferings.

Our country is suffering from some shortages. The prices have arisen and have arisen tremendously. We do not wish to conceal this fact but we should also try to understand as to how these shortages came about. You are aware of the drought which has affected us during the last two years, particularly in Maharashtra, Gujarat and Rajasthan but in

Mysore....

in Mysore and some other States too the drought has been an unprecedented scale which has not been witnessed duri last fifty years. But our people did not lose heart.

I have toured those areas and can vouchsafe for th courage and fortitude with which they have faced the dro The foreigners who went there to see the conditions were prised to see people's courage and determination to face challenge — whether they dug the land or broke stones were busy in constructing dams. They sang as they worked No one complained. If they asked for something it was on the means to rehabilitate themselves. We have to spread spirit of determination throughout the entire country.

The areas producing millet, maize and groundnut wer particularly affected by the drought. Thus, the shortag began, the prices increased, the chain reaction of short was set in motion, the demand increased and the prices ro still further. There were reasons for the price-rise in some cases but in many cases there was no justification fo the price-rise. The drought had not affected only our country, but large parts of Asia and Africa as well suffe this and had to import grains on a large scale. Thus, the prices of foodgrains rose in other countries and affected the prices in our country too. The prices have risen not in these countries but even in the affluent and advanced countries of the world.

The same story of shortages, sufferings and complaint would be revealed if we go through their newspapers or tal

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to the peoples of those countries. This does not mean that the causes for price-rise in these countries are the same as in India. In fact they are totally different. But national boundaries cannot check the economic winds. These affect the prices in our country, as these countries have to import the required goods which lead to higher prices in these countries and which in turn affect the prices of goods in our country. Thus we should see our problems in this wider perspective.

Some people accuse the Government for extravagance. They ask as to where all this money is going? Where has this money gone? Massive amounts have been spent in providing relief to one crore people affected by the drought and you are aware of the huge amounts which we had to spend earlier to look after the refugees from Bangladesh. Then came the war. All this could have been compensated by a good harvest but it was the other way round and a terrible drought not only wiped out the harvest but even the wells and rivers went dry and inflation increased.

The Government is making all efforts to cut down expenditure. We have affected a reduction of Rs.400 crores in the expenditure contemplated earlier under various programmes for each Ministry andthe State Governments and every department of the Government has been asked to cut its expenditure on non-essential programmes or to temporarily shelve them. Some of the essential public services may be affected by this reduction but we cannot help it. These are hard times,..

hard times, and as in a family, so in a nation we have to fix priorities. India is a large family and we have to mobilise our resources and use them judiciously. In this context the main responsibility is that of the Government but in this the public is equally involved to ensure that they too reduce their expenditure to the minimum.

We all feel annoyed when we hear of blackmarketing and shortages which the people are facing. But the same goods are sold at higher prices in the same shop behind the counter. I have absolutely no doubt that those who hoard or who sell goods in the blackmarket should be dealt with severely and awarded stringent punishment. These people, however, do not belong to a different category. Things are sold in the black-market because there are people to purchase them. If people are not prepared to buy at blackmarket price, the traders would not be able to sell them.

We have seen that for whatever reasons, some people have obstructed the procurement of foodgrains. If there is a fire, the only question is how to put it out and nobody questions how and where from the water is to be obtained. Whatever be our food policy, whether it is liked or not, is it not the duty of everybody to see that wheat is procured and distributed to all equitably or who need it so that nobody starves.

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This is the responsibility of the entire community. We are accused that we have taken over the wholesale trade in wheat. Some people think that this has led to shortage but no one can prove that grain would have reached the shops if we had not taken this step. According to the information received from various sources it has proved that had we not taken over wholesale trade in wheat it would not have reached the people and would have gone into the blackmarket depriving the weaker section of the society. Only those who could have afforded a higher price would have got it. The middle class and the urban people have faced difficulty but we have been able to give grains anyhow to those who needed them most. I do not, therefore, accept there was anything wrong in this policy.

Another question is that why do we not pay more to the farmer. If we now pay higher price for the wheat it will further affect the price of other commodities. The farmer, no doubt, would have got more but it would have caused more hardship to the other section of the population. We all have to swim together. Thus some people may benefit but the rest will suffer.

During the struggle in Bangladesh when the people were rejoicing I had warned that the country would have to pay a heavy price for it in terms of economic and social tension. And so it happened, and the

Government..

Government is fully prepared to meet this challenge. I assure you on this occasion that the Government is determined to solve the problem of shortages, rising prices and take strong action against anti-social elements. Some steps are being taken, programmes have been chalked out and others will be initiated. But no one can do miracles alone. No Government can solve all problems by itself. We have democracy in our country under which people have got many rights and have to bear many responsibilities. Unless everybody share responsibility in this matter, the situation cannot improve. As I said if some people sell at a higher price and others are prepared to pay that price, then this malady cannot be checked. The people have to be alert.

It is necessary that the Government reduces its expenditure but it is also incumbent on the people to cut down their expenses. I do know that there are people in our country who are too poor to reduce their expenditure as they are not getting enough even today. There is a vast number who can hardly make both ends meet. In our present-day society the standard of living has gone up high. Certain consumer items not heardof earlier have become daily necessities. We should decide to make ddowith the minimum.

Fortunately there has been good rain this year but it would take some months for the new crop to reach the market and we have to make arrangements till that time. We seek.....

seek the people's cooperation to manage with the stocks in hand and with what is being imported to stall any serious situation. All the housewives and others should scrupulously avoid waste. This would enable us to tide over the difficult months ahead. The people should not take the law into their hands to deal with the hoarders and profiteers but inform the concerned authorities. We have to create an atmosphere against hoarding. Some people think that it is only through agitations and bunds that their grievances could be heard. But where does this lead to? The work stops, there is ∠ and violence and the very items we need become scarce. The prices go up. If there is loot there will not be proper distribution, prices will further go up and there will be strikes. You must have seen in Delhi and other places how people have to face difficulties. It is the farmer who feeds the people and who forms the backbone of our economy. It is his bounden duty to increase production and make it available to Government so that equitable distribution is ensured. First, we have to increase production, procure foodgrains and then distribute it among the people. In this we have all to cooperate.

Action has been taken to step up arrangements for increasing production of power, agricultural products and the situation is steadily improving. Along with the demand for personal freedom we have also to ensure that there is no violence and people maintain law and or

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If there is a clash, it is the common man who has to bear the brunt.

Employees also form an important section of the society. Our progress, specially industrial growth depends upon them. They too have demands. I realise that strike is an instrument to achieve these demands. But there are times in the life of a nation when individual demands and individual needs have to be set aside, as today in the larger interest of the country and the society, we hope that no factory will be closed. Mill owners and industrialists, whatever their difficulties, will bear them anyhow and see that the mills and factories continue to function. In the same manner, I would request the employees to solve their problemsthrough mutual discussions and negotiations. But under no circumstances there should be let up in production. This is the time to take such a decision and act with a sense of responsibility.

Similarly, the common man has also to understand and realise his responsibilities and obligations. Certain things we can tell and others people can think and tell us. Our democracy does not mean that you only cast your vote. The people of the country voted for us in the elections and we have tried to take such steps which would enable even the smallest man to have confidence and raise the prestige of India. This has happened. But even after this can we say we have all carried out our responsibilities?

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Our ancient scriptures teach us to maintain equanimity during trials and tribulations, amidst stresses and strains and not to lose our perspective in joy or sorrow. But what actually happens is that any happy development sends us into ecstasy while a small difficulty is enough to despair us. The question is whether we want to be a nation of those who cry, complain or quit in the face of difficulty or a country of the courageous who squarely and boldly face their trials and privations. This question has to be answered today in our country by the young and the aged alike.

In this gathering today there are many freedom fighters of the yore, old in years no doubt but young at heart. Their zest for life and enthusiasm is as intense as of any man in his thirties, forties and fifties. Today we seek the cooperation of these young veterans to guide us, to imbue us with their courage and determination.

Rains or no rains, the country must forge ahead. The programmes have to be completed. In war or peace we do not wish to slacken the pace of our progress. Some people counsel a Plan holiday. This is dangerous, for, this implies mortgaging India's future to present comforts, ignoring completely the country's poor. There cannot and there will not be any Plan holiday.

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When I last spoke to you here I had mentioned the changes coming about in the international scene, these changes continue and new friendships are giving a new complexion to this scene. This continent is still to reach the kind of peace and adjustments it should have reached. People blame us. I will not repeat here the story of the prisoners of war of which you are all well aware. Governments of Bangladesh and our own have made some proposals, generous proposals which have been hailed throughout the world. Negotiations are continuing and will resumed in a few days. But should these negotiations fall through the people of India, the people of Pakistan and the whole world will know that the Governmenments of India or Bangladesh cannot be blamed for this. They will know who is responsible for the prisoners not going back to their country and who is creating obstructions.

We have together faced many a hurdle. Sometimes we came out with flying colours, sometimes success eluded us. Now we face our acid test as a nation and if we are able to tackle it resolutely and courageously we will have a future ahead of us burnished and bright like gold tried by fire. And so will be our people.

I will repeat my question today: what kind of a future and a people are we aiming at? We want a people whose hopes will never be shattered. We want a people w

voice....

voice, the voice of peace and friendship, is echoed in all corners of the world. Our great leaders held up to us the ideals -- of a new world, of a new vision -- and we have to fulfil their promises. But that is not enough. A new generation has come up. I hope this new generation will be the harbinger of a new light. They will be disciplined and brave and will show the veterans present here that they are second to none. They will build a new India.

Whether you are present here or sitting by your radio or television set, please join me now to raise the slogan of 'Jai Hind'. This is the slogan of India's freedom, unity, strength and her radiant future. Jai Hind.

BRB/SGL/...

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15/8/2007